

FIRST CUSTOMER

First Customer — 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers — Day 8: Handling Objections with A.R.T.

Study guide · Self-study

10 Days to Your First Paying Customers · Day 8: Handling Objections with A.R.T.

How to Use This Guide

This is your guide for Day 8 of 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers. You work through it alone, at your own pace, in your own business. Read one section, then stop and write. The writing is where the learning happens.

By today you have found your target customer, opened the conversation, run discovery, built an offer and presented it with A.I.M. Then the customer said no. Or said it costs too much. Or said they need to think about it. Today you learn what to do in that moment.

Here is the good news: an objection is not a rejection. In most cases it is the customer telling you exactly which piece of the decision is still unclear. Your job is to find that piece, not to argue with the person.

Keep a notebook beside you. When you see a script line, say it out loud once before you write your own version. Your words should sound like you, not like this page.

> **NOTES**
>
> Most founders lose deals not because the offer was wrong, but because they answered the first objection they heard instead of the real one underneath it. Slow down today. Slow is the technique.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

These are the four things this guide is built to give you. Read them now, and read them again at the end of the day.

- Knowledge: You will know A.R.T., MEDJAY's own framework for handling objections and concerns, in full, and the Four Friction Blocks used to diagnose which objection you are actually hearing.
- Attitude: You will treat an objection as information about the decision, not as an attack on you or your price.
- Skill: You will be able to take a real objection from one of your own prospects and run all three A.R.T. steps, in order, out loud.
- Upskill: You will be able to name the friction block behind an objection and then ask a question that tests whether your reading is right.

> **NOTES**
>
> You will not sound polished on day one. That is normal. Aim for the right order of steps, not a perfect sentence.

Why Objections Are Good News

An objection means the customer is still in the conversation. A silent customer who stops replying is far harder to reach than one who tells you the price is too high. The person who argues with your price has already imagined owning what you sell. They are doing the mental work of deciding.

The psychology here matters. When someone is asked to commit money to something new, the brain shifts from fast, comfortable, automatic thinking to slow, effortful evaluation. Kahneman described this in Thinking, Fast and Slow as System 1 and System 2. During that slow evaluation, the customer starts scanning for reasons to stop. Every concern they raise is a reason they found. They are not being difficult. They are trying to protect themselves from a bad decision.

Your instinct will be to defend. You will want to list features, drop the price, or explain again. Resist that. Defending confirms to the customer that you heard their concern as an attack, and it turns a decision into a contest. You are not trying to win a contest. You are trying to help them decide well, and then let them decide.

There is a second reason objections deserve respect. Most of what a customer says out loud is a surface statement. "It's too expensive" is rarely a statement about capacity to pay. It usually means the weight of the decision feels bigger than the value they can currently see. Your work starts at that gap.

> **NOTES**
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> Watch for the rescue reflex: the urge to fill a silence after the customer states a concern. Let the concern sit for two seconds. Sometimes they keep talking and tell you the real reason.

A.R.T., MEDJAY's Own Framework for Objections

A.R.T. is MEDJAY's framework for handling objections and concerns, developed by Steven Saad. It has three steps, always used in order, as one chain. You do not skip a step, and you do not stop after one.

A: Acknowledge. Label the customer's feeling, with no "but" after it. Acknowledging is not agreeing. It is proving you heard the concern before you respond to it. The word "but" erases everything said before it, so it never belongs here.

R: Reframe. Shift the decision criterion from the visible cost to the cost of inaction. Do not defend features. This is the step where the value lives, and it only works after a real Acknowledge.

T: Transition. Ask a calibrated how or what question. Never a yes/no close, never a trade or concession. A how or what question hands the thinking back to the customer in a way they can answer in their own words.

Before Acknowledge, there is the Mandatory Pause (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Voss and Raz): a required pause of a few seconds after the customer states the concern, before you speak again. It feels long. It is not long. It gives the customer room to keep going, and it stops you from answering the first sentence instead of the real problem.

Use A.R.T. only for objections and concerns. It is not a planning tool, a note-taking structure or a way to review a day. It is the response chain for the moment someone pushes back.

- A: Acknowledge: Label the customer's feeling, with no "but" after it.
- R: Reframe: Shift the decision criterion from the visible cost to the cost of inaction. Do not defend features.
- T: Transition: Ask a calibrated how/what question. Never a yes/no close, never a trade or concession.

> **NOTES**
>
> A common mistake is a fake acknowledge: "I understand, but..." That is not Acknowledge. If you hear yourself say "but," start the step again.

The Four Friction Blocks: Diagnosing What You Heard

Objections sound alike and mean different things. The Four Friction Blocks help you sort them. Each objection is diagnosed into one of four blocks, each block is tested with its own clarifying question, and the diagnosis comes from the customer's own words, not from your guess.

Comparison Confusion. The customer is measuring your offer against a mismatched benchmark. A B2C example: they compare your small-batch furniture to a mass-market flat-pack price without accounting for materials or lifespan. A B2B example: they compare your monthly software fee to the cost of a freelancer's one-off project. Test it with a clarifying question about what they are comparing against.

Trust Deficit. The customer is unsure about the process, not the product. They worry about what happens after they pay, who answers the phone, what the paperwork means. Test it by asking what would need to be true for them to feel confident about how this would work.

Regret Avoidance. The customer is afraid of choosing wrong. This shows up most with a first purchase of its kind, a large sum, or a decision they will have to explain to someone else. Test it by asking what their worry is if it does not work out.

Value Disconnect. The price was never connected to an outcome the customer cares about, so the number sits alone. Test it by asking what would make the difference between this being worth it and not worth it.

Treat every read as a hypothesis, not a diagnosis. You will be wrong sometimes. The clarifying question is how you find out. Naming the block to yourself changes what you reframe: comparison needs a different benchmark, trust needs process evidence, regret needs risk reversal, and value needs the outcome in the customer's words.

- Comparison Confusion: a mismatched benchmark is in play. Test: "What are you comparing this against?"
- Trust Deficit: doubt about the process, not the product. Test: "What would you need to see about how this works?"

- Regret Avoidance: fear of choosing wrong. Test: "What worries you if it doesn't work out?"
- Value Disconnect: the price is detached from an outcome. Test: "What would make this clearly worth it for you?"

> **NOTES**
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> If you cannot place an objection in a block, you have not heard enough yet. Ask one clarifying question instead of building a reframe on a guess.

The Buyer Psychology Behind the Reframe

The reframe works because of how people weigh outcomes. Losing something of a known size feels bigger than gaining something of the same size. That asymmetry means a customer comparing two prices is not weighing value evenly. They feel the money leaving their account sharply, and the benefit arriving is abstract and later.

Your reframe changes the comparison, not the price. Instead of your fee against the alternative fee, the customer compares the cost of acting against the cost of not acting. If nothing changes when they wait, waiting is genuinely fine and you should say so. Honesty is what makes the reframe credible.

Framing matters too, and Tversky and Kahneman's research on framing showed that the same facts feel different depending on how the choice is presented. If you present a fee as an expense, it reads as loss. If you present the same number next to the cost of the problem it removes, the customer has something to compare it to. Same number, different lens.

One more piece. A customer who feels pushed will push back. Reactance, described by Brehm, is the reflex people have when their freedom of choice feels threatened. A hard reframe delivered as pressure produces the opposite of what you want. A calm reframe, with evidence the customer can check, followed by a question instead of a close, keeps their freedom intact. That is why the Transition step is a how or what question.

> **NOTES**
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> Use only facts you can verify. One real number the customer can check beats five impressive ones they cannot.

Worked Example: B2B (Software)

Practice example: A founder sells a scheduling tool to a dental practice group. The practice manager says: "The monthly fee is more than we budgeted for admin software."

Pause. Two seconds. Do not speak.

Acknowledge: "It sounds like this sits above a number you'd already settled on, and that's uncomfortable." No "but." The manager nods and adds: "Yes, and we already pay for two systems."

That addition is new information. The customer is now comparing your tool to two existing subscriptions, which is Comparison Confusion. Put the hypothesis to the test: "When you compare this to the two systems you already pay for, what does that comparison look like?" The manager explains that the two systems do not talk to each other, and someone re-enters appointments by hand every week.

Reframe: "So the number you're weighing isn't only the fee. It's the fee against the hours of re-entering appointments every week, plus the double bookings that come from it." This uses the manager's own information, not invented savings. The founder does not lower the fee.

Transition: "How would you want to weigh those side by side before you decide?" The manager suggests a two-week trial on one location with a clear measure: manual re-entry time before and after.

Notice the whole chain. Acknowledge, then the clarifying question, then Reframe with the customer's data, then Transition with a question. The objection did not disappear. It turned into a decision they can make.

> **NOTES**
>
> Look for the detail a customer adds after you acknowledge. That sentence is usually the real objection, and it tells you which friction block you are dealing with.

Worked Example: B2C (Service)

Practice example: A founder runs a small home-organizing service. A homeowner says: "Honestly, that's a lot for someone to come and tidy my cupboards."

Pause.

Acknowledge: "I can see why that number feels high when it's framed as tidying." No "but."

Now you need the block. Regret Avoidance sounds like this: the homeowner is worried they will pay and feel foolish if the result does not last. Value Disconnect is different: they simply have not connected the number to anything they want. Ask one clarifying question rather than guessing: "What would need to happen for this to feel clearly worth the money?"

The homeowner says: "I just don't want to pay for it and be back to chaos in a month." That is Regret Avoidance, in their words, not yours.

Reframe: "So the risk you're weighing isn't the price of the visit. It's paying and finding yourself back where you started in a few weeks." The founder then names one real, checkable fact about the process: the follow-up visit and the written routine that comes with it, both of which already exist in the offer. Nothing new is invented. No discount is offered.

Transition: "What would need to be in place for you to feel confident it holds after we leave?" The homeowner asks about the kitchen first. They agree to start with one room and a check-in date. The whole conversation took ninety seconds.

If instead the homeowner had said "my neighbor paid less for a cleaner," you would have been in Comparison Confusion, and the reframe would compare scope and outcome, not price per hour.

NOTES

Never invent a guarantee to beat regret. If you cannot point to something real already in your offer, say what you genuinely can and cannot promise. That honesty is itself a reframe.

What Not to Do

These are the moves that feel natural and cost you the deal.

Arguing with the concern. It tells the customer their judgment was wrong, and people do not buy from someone who makes them feel wrong.

Discounting to end the discomfort. Giving a concession for nothing teaches the customer that your first number was not real. That is a negotiation rule on its own: trade, don't concede. If you ever do adjust terms, ask for something of equal value in return, such as a faster decision or a smaller scope. And never bargain against yourself by lowering your own price before the customer has asked twice.

Piling on features. A long list of features during an objection reads as noise, and it makes the customer work harder to feel good about the decision. One clear point beats five.

Ending on a yes/no question. "Does that make sense?" invites a polite yes that means nothing. A how or what question gets you a real answer.

Inventing urgency. Never claim limited availability or a deadline you do not actually have. Real limits exist, such as stock, a delivery window or a booking calendar, and they are fine to state when true. Fake ones end the relationship.

- ☐ Name the objection in the customer's own words before you respond.
- ☐ Pause for a few seconds after they finish.
- ☐ Acknowledge with no "but."
- ☐ Ask one clarifying question to test the friction block.
- ☐ Reframe using only facts you can verify.
- ☐ Transition with a how or what question.
- ☐ Offer no concession the customer did not trade for.

NOTES

If you catch yourself mid-sentence defending a feature, stop, say "let me put that better," and go back to Acknowledge.

Apply It in Your Role

You run your own business, so this is all yours to apply. There is no manager to approve the words and no policy to hide behind. That is an advantage: you can decide today what your honest reframe is for each common objection.

Do this now. Take your offer from Day 7, the one you presented with A.I.M., and list the three objections you actually hear. Not the ones you fear. The ones you have heard from real people in the last month.

For each one, write which friction block you think it is, one clarifying question to test it, one checkable fact you can use in the Reframe, and one how or what question to use in the Transition. Test this on a real prospect before the next day of this program. A calibration: if you are doing more than a third of the talking in these moments, you are probably defending instead of asking.

- Objection as you actually hear it: ____
- Likely friction block: ____
- Clarifying question to test it: ____
- Checkable fact for the Reframe: ____
- How or what question for the Transition: ____

> **NOTES**
>
> Write the objection in the customer's exact words. Your reframe will be sharper when it mirrors their phrasing back to them.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you look at the model answers at the end of this guide. Say each one out loud once. If it sounds like this page and not like you, rewrite it in your own words. The principle matters more than the wording.

- A B2B prospect says: "We like it, but your price is higher than the other quote we got." Write your Acknowledge, your one clarifying question, your Reframe and your Transition.
- A B2C customer says: "I need to think about it." Write what you say in the next fifteen seconds, without pushing and without ending the conversation.
- A customer says: "I'm not sure your process is reliable. What if it doesn't get done on time?" Which friction block is this, and what clarifying question do you ask first?
- A prospect says: "Honestly, we're a small operation, and this just isn't the right moment." Write an A.R.T. chain that is honest, including the possibility that waiting really is better for them.

> **NOTES**
>
> Notice that none of the model answers end with a yes/no question. Check yours for the same thing.

Key Takeaways

Five things to carry into your next conversation.

An objection is information about the decision, not a rejection of you. The customer is telling you which piece is still unclear.

A.R.T. is a chain, not a menu: Acknowledge with no "but," Reframe from visible cost to the cost of inaction with evidence, then Transition with a calibrated how or what question.

Diagnose before you reframe. The Four Friction Blocks (Comparison Confusion, Trust Deficit, Regret Avoidance and Value Disconnect) each need a different reframe, and each is tested with its own clarifying question.

The Mandatory Pause comes first. A few seconds of silence after the objection is where you find the real one.

Never trade away value to end your own discomfort. Real limits are fine to mention. Invented ones destroy trust.

> **NOTES**
>
> If you remember only one line from today, remember this: acknowledge before you reframe, every time.

Quiz

Answer the five questions below before you read the answer key. Write your answers down. Then check the key and read the explanation for each one, including the ones you got right.

1. What is the correct order of the A.R.T. steps?

   A. Reframe, Acknowledge, Transition
   B. Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition
   C. Acknowledge, Transition, Reframe
   D. Transition, Reframe, Acknowledge

2. A customer compares your hand-made product to a cheap mass-market version with a shorter lifespan. Which friction block is most likely?

   A. Trust Deficit
   B. Value Disconnect
   C. Regret Avoidance
   D. Comparison Confusion

3. Which sentence is a genuine Acknowledge step?

   A. "I understand, but let me explain the price."
   B. "That's actually not what we charge for that."
   C. "It sounds like this sits above the number you had in mind, and that's uncomfortable."
   D. "Does that make sense now?"

4. What belongs in the Transition step?

   A. A yes/no question

B. A discount to show flexibility

C. A list of your main features

D. A calibrated how or what question

5. A prospect says: "I'm worried I'll pay and it won't be worth it." Which clarifying question tests for Value Disconnect?

   A. "What are you comparing us against?"

   B. "What would make this clearly worth it for you?"

   C. "Would a discount help?"

   D. "Are you worried it won't last?"

Upskill Challenge

Before Day 9, run A.R.T. on three real objections in your own business. Not three imagined ones. Three live conversations with people who have actually pushed back.

For each one, write four lines: the objection in their words, the friction block you suspected and the clarifying question you used, the Reframe you gave, and the how or what question you closed with. Then note what the customer did next.

After the three, mark which step felt weakest: Acknowledge, Reframe or Transition. Write one sentence about why. Most founders find Acknowledge hardest, because it asks you to stay quiet and let the concern be true for a moment. If that is yours, practice the pause alone: say an objection out loud, then count three seconds before you answer.

Bring the three written examples to Day 9. The close begins where the objection ended.

- Conversation 1: objection, suspected block, clarifying question, Reframe, Transition, what happened: ____
- Conversation 2: objection, suspected block, clarifying question, Reframe, Transition, what happened: ____
- Conversation 3: objection, suspected block, clarifying question, Reframe, Transition, what happened: ____
- Weakest step and why: ____
- One thing I will change in the next conversation: ____

> **NOTES**
>
> Choose objections that genuinely worried you. The ones that feel easy will not teach you anything.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your own wording will be better for your business. Read each one, then rewrite it in your voice.

Question 1, B2B higher quote. Acknowledge: "So when you put the two quotes side by side, ours is the bigger number, and that needs to be worth it." Clarifying question: "What are you comparing when you line the two up?" Suppose they answer that the other quote is per project and yours is monthly. Reframe: "So the real comparison is the one-off project cost against a monthly fee that continues only while it delivers. Is that how you're weighing it?" Transition: "What would you want to see in the first month to know it's earning that fee?" No discount. No feature defense.

Question 2, B2C "I need to think about it." This is not yet an objection, so do not start a full reframe. Answer: "Of course, that's a real decision. So I can be useful, what's the part you'd most want to think through?" Then wait. That silence is the Mandatory Pause. Whatever they say next tells you the friction block. If they name the price, you are in a value or comparison conversation. If they name the risk, you are in Regret Avoidance.

Question 3, reliability doubt. This is Trust Deficit. It is doubt about the process, not the product. Ask: "What would you need to see about how we work to feel confident about timing?" Then answer with something checkable: a schedule, a named contact, a written scope. Answer the question fully. Then Transition: "How would you like to handle the timing question before you decide?"

Question 4, "not the right moment." Acknowledge: "It sounds like the timing really is the constraint, not the idea itself." Clarifying question: "What would need to change for this to become a priority?" Suppose they name a slow season or a pending decision. Reframe honestly: "So the cost of waiting is mostly that the slow season is exactly when this is hardest to fix. Does that match what you're seeing?" If waiting really is better for them, say so and agree a date to talk again. Transition: "What's a sensible date to revisit this?" An honest reframe sometimes means booking a later conversation, not a sale today.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. The chain runs Acknowledge, then Reframe, then Transition, in that order, every time.
- 2. D. The customer is measuring against a mismatched benchmark, which is Comparison Confusion.
- 3. C. It labels the feeling and adds no "but"; option A cancels the acknowledgement with "but."
- 4. D. The Transition is a calibrated how or what question, never a yes/no close and never a concession.
- 5. B. Value Disconnect is tested by asking what would make the price clearly worth it; option A points at Comparison Confusion.

> **NOTES**
>
> Notice that every model answer ends with a question the customer can answer in their own words, and none of them offers a discount.

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